

Dec 2020 -- Jelle Bruineberg -- Embodied cognition and the attention crisis

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okay and welcome to the December 2020 Eno seminar which will be presented by y bber from MC University although currently inar will Beed so um welcome yell and um we will have we we're muted there for a moment thank you um yell did um you did your your PhD in Amsterdam with Eric gelt is that right and um completed postto yeah sorry sorry I was just I I still had the YouTube link open so I was hearing double sounds so it's what's going wrong but now now now we're now I'm full Focus yeah good the joys of of the zoom uh seminar exactly so you are currently you have moved to a postto position in mcari University as of sometime during this um decade of a year and will continue uh in that position for at least another year as well if at any point you actually get south of the Equator yeah yeah so it's a it's a three-year position but indeed so far um I've been working remotely but yeah as everybody actually so yeah indeed so um the we we have a few people logged on and we are expecting a couple of live participants for the discussion later which ought to be um Lively and interesting I did now um I mentioned when we spoke before the possibility we we might uh give a signal boost to something if you have come across a reading or uh some kind of resource in recently that you'd like to you think well that's that's something the Eno Community might be interested in in knowing about have you come across any good papers or yeah wait I'll I'll I'll um share the screen I made a little commercial break slide you can see it now right yeah yeah so uh uh here it is uh so uh on the left uh there's son Dean's uh book an active Psychiatry we just had a a reading group on it with the with the people in Amsterdam uh and I can warmly recommend it I think it Deals Deals with the topics of Psychiatry but also pushes an activism further in a number of directions mainly that of the notion of values uh I think in the more existentialist Direction and has some uh uh really good points in in developing a more relational realist metaphysics for an activism so I really uh enjoy that um and the other one is a little bit of Shameless self-promotion uh but I know many people in an activism are interested in the links

with the with with the free energy principle I worked on this in my PhD uh as well and I received lots of students who who who really want to work on all that that that stuff and uh I just been uh publishing this preprint uh uh a few days ago where we share some doubts about the possibility of such a kind of approach specifically with the notion of Mark blankets so this is not what we're going to talk about today at all but I thought for those interested in the more free energy principle kind of things I think this is a conversation which at some point we need to have uh with those people uh yeah excellent thank you very much for that and um I love the idea of a commercial break we might continue to use that one as things go on nice but now I think we have where we have a good few people online God bless um the pandemic it has uh pushed people for fullon internet engagement and uh we have one or two people coming into the live session we'll keep them we'll keep them quiet until later on but in the meantime uh y if I can invite you toh to present the December 2020 endel seminar uh thanks a lot Merck and um so hello everyone thanks for having me and um I'm just going to pretend we somehow have cornered off a little uh a little corner of the internet and have a chat among friends uh it's somehow a bit weird to know that you're being broadcasted to to to the worldwide web uh so I treat this as a kind of internal uh seminar and uh so the topic today is that topic of my research project in in mcari uh called the world of the fingertips embod cognition and the attention crisis and this is a bit of a new topic for me and I'm still experimenting a little bit uh with how to best introduce introduce it and so how I've been doing it was kind of starting with big alarming claims about the attention economy and the idea that human attention is being harvested for commercial gain so this is the kind of kind of alarming story that you find in sh zub's uh work the age of surveillance capitalism and also this is I just have the books here this very good book by James Williams stand out of our light um I can later on share the links to those books or so uh and in that literature you find a more or less explicit or implicit uh view of human nature and sometimes it's rather cognitivism is an extremely behavioristic View uh there's a lot of evolutionary psychology in that literature how we're just wired to be U addicted to the internet or to smartphones Etc um and then having presented all those positions you can show like look actually there is some some space here for a more kind of embodied and inactive position that shows that both the the kind of vulnerabilities that we have in relationship to those Technologies but also the possibility to have somehow in interacting with them maintain uh some kind of autonomy um I tried this a few times and that results in a kind of big big stroke kind of kind of picture where you really uh have competing pictures of human nature um and so today I want to try something a little bit different and more trace a

little bit my own thinking and how I arrived at this project and this really starts from more active principles and arrives in the end about the logical questions about human nature and how that how that works so this is the experiment for today and then the starting point now is is um actually uh something that that I was reminded of again in in Sonic's book um and that often in an activism people write about uh sense making as a kind of projection of value on a neutral world so we kind of enact this world we create it Rec constitute it um and in some sense that's right right that that that world is is a co-production of uh uh uh us uh but there's also something and in H's terms it might be something like the tronus of sense making right so in in activist terms we we find ourselves making sense of the world and in kind of the Amsterdam terminology uh we find ourselves being solicited in a meaningful Way by a field of affordances right so we don't choose we don't decide which things we we are affected by how we make sense of the world uh but we find ourselves being affected in this way and that is actually where agency starts um so we encountered this this this world that is that is not completely of our own making and of course there's a lots of aspects there that do contribute to this to this world of course personal history typically something like like history of interactions with the environment uh the kind of skills that you have acquired during your lifetime uh the social material environment itself uh including all the practices of the education of attention Etc uh a form of life the behavior settings I believe the last answer seminar was was on on on Behavior setting um the layout of of the affordance in the environment and and like making this list I got to the question like what what about Technologies what about the kind of digital Technologies uh uh that we carry around uh with us and um of course these aspects here are not mutually exclusive and I think there's a lot of overlap between them but these are more like I think from different theoretical Vantage points in in activism you you arrive at some of those some some of those Concepts a bit more permanently than other ones um and so I kind of noticed that I've been showing uh uh these kind of pictures uh for years as kind of scenario of the Hallmark of skilled action where an agent is engaging with multiple affordances at the same time and somehow maintaining a grip on this interaction with the environment and to my own embarrassment actually I I suddenly realized that the amount of technology that that that's going on in this in this picture the amount of technological mediation that that that's going on here and if you come at it from a more affordance perspective this really leads to a couple of embarrassing questions that I was at least at that point not able and still not actually able to to answer properly right so it is this an affordance um and you might think in terms of solicitation of invitation that's definitely the case if you

think about when you read a book um uh and the phone is lying next to you you can definitely can feel the solicitation the invitation of of something even without the kind of push-up messages that you might every once in a while encounter um and yes it is an Affordance in the sense you can do lots of things with it um but other you also might thinking no no it's the phone itself is not the affordance it's a kind of Gateway it's a kind of mediated to affordances and what what what are the affordances yeah maybe the apps on it or the things you can do on the app so there's a kind of kind of uh uh uh the phone is a kind of entrance point in a new kind of uh uh Niche and I didn't quite have the terminology to to to uh and the concepts to think about it um and of course there is a large history of of what and this is a term I think that's from uh uh postphenomenology so kind of more Phil philosophy of Technology angle to uh uh uh to phenomenology and they call this technological mediation so the mediation of intentionality through by Technologies and of course we find this in higher already about the the hammer well if you carry the hang the the hammer then the whole world shows up as for hamable as so as kind of affording hammering and the moxon you find the example of the blind person's cane and these are all forms of the mediation of of of of intentionality but kind of opening up to the same world in a different kind of way at least that's would be my way of my intuitive way of characterizing this and then the question is like so what what about these these uh digital Technologies right they they don't in a sense they seem similar that they are transparent right you see through the hammer you see it through the cane and you see it through your phone into something else uh but rather than showing up allowing you the world to show up in a different way it it it opens it shows up a new kind of world in which action possibilities are aligned in a different kind of way so that the question is like how to think is is there think about this is there something like a digital Niche a cyber Niche is that the right kind of kind of terminology um and so I want to as a kind of take a take a few steps back about how to think about the influence of technology I want to to to uh mention this example from the from the 50s really or the early 60s um and that's that's the example of the remote control uh for television so in another book very good book the the the Attention Merchants the subtitle is the Epic struggle to get inside our heads um uh the writer Tim Wu uh vividly captures the kind of sentiment at the at the end of the 50s about the arrival of commercial breaks on television and uh the Zenith radio company orders Engineers to kind of find an antidote against his arrival of of of Comm commercial brakes and they uh develop this device that allowed you to to shoot out commercial uh uh or advertisements and the the result is something like an ad blocker of onra where you can kind of shoot at your television and

mute uh the sound and later on switch channels Etc and of course this this is something that we now know as a as a remote control and uh this was really meant as a kind of way for consumers to uh gain and maintain autonomy be able to decide what you want to to look at uh W call is the resistance against the industrialized Harvest of attention I think this is the kind of terminology that we find now again in in the literature on the attention economy um and then W kind of vividly uh uh described and this is an abbreviated quote uh how that that dream of autonomy was really shortlived so you're right so the remote control made it almost effortless practically non-volitional to redirect our attention in fact in the in the course of sustained Channel serving the voluntary aspect of attentional control may disappear entirely having thus surrender the mind is simply jumping about and following whatever grabs it uh so you can really think here about the idea like you're sitting late at night you should be going to bed you want to go to bed in some sense of wanting but there is this kind of Behavioral cycle going on of sustained uh channel surfing and I think W highlights a few key points here right the that something like fision or executive control seems to be disappearing uh uh entirely from that episode um and in a sense in some sense this the kind of uh disappearance of control is also the Hallmark of uh the kind of descriptions of skilled action that drivers gives kind of kind of skilled coping skilled mindless coping uh although this is a Mindless coping but not in the in the right sense uh of the world so there there parallel there between the kind of skilled coping examples but also of course big differences so I think Wu present us here with a puzzle uh and the pieces are something like friction or sensory motor effort it becomes so easy uh uh to change channels uh that we somehow become more impulsive F and executive control are are disappearing and the question is how to put that puzzle uh together and so I think what you find here is really uh and and I'll call it clashing anthropologies and it's it's anthropology in a sense it's it's sketches or pictures of human nature uh but then that human nature is not something that's that's immutable and unchangeable but something that is that is yeah you might say enacted um so this remote control is really designed for a particular kind of agent and that's an agent who knows what it wants and just needs the easiest means to realize in the world what it wants so the kind of distinction between what what are your goals what are your values uh and what you can do if you if you have a strong distinction between those then then it's an good advice to to have um it's it's a less Ideal tool I think for a situated agent that figures out in interacting with the world what it what it wants so the kind of the goals and the concerns and the solicitations are not independent of your interaction with the world but they shaping each other um so the kind of the anthropology of autonomy we are rational beings we

we know what to do and we just need to uh uh uh shape the world so that it becomes as easy as possible for us to know what to to to realize what we do um I think that in this case had very unintended consequences in many cases of uh uh behavioral design in in in a modern technology that's not unintended that's that's completely uh uh intended the kind of Behavioral effects it is it is having um so what you find in the literature really are two two narratives here on attention but the narratives are way more than narratives on attention there narratives on autonomy the narratives on agency there there there are the these kind of uh uh um kind of anthropologies I say um and so I already mentioned James Williams uh book and this is stand out of a light you see the subtitle freedom and resistance in the attention economy and so this is really an attempt to describe uh what our possibilities are in the in in the age of the attention economy uh um how how we can think about Freedom what is at stake uh and how we can regain it and part of Williams narrative is uh is following Herbert Simon in saying that well there there is historically there has been a kind of scarcity of of information and therefore an abundance of attention but now in this kind of information Rich times we live in times of information overload and therefore scarcity of attention so what we need to do is put something like a boundary in place to kind of separate us from from the information in the environment so that we can reflect and decide and be autonomous again um on the other hand we have a completely different uh narrative and I think that narrative uh um um follows the more more behaviorist principles so so Nal writes also I think the subtitles and the titles are really telling here so hooked how to build habit forming products uh and it's a it's a story about how to get users hooked to your to your products and that's a story about you you can make the environment as inviting as possible but the the the the the real thing is to get inside the agent and hack their the habits right so it's in in environmental competition there's still a lot of competition between different kind of companies but if you can be prior to that and instill in the user an urge or something like this to uh uh uh to engage with a product then then you're really talking then you're really getting people people hooked and interestingly in terms of a kind of quasy phenomenology I think AAL is really uh closer to the point in terms of kind of idea of that indeed if you structure how agents find themselves in the world what kind of habits they have how they are solicited by this world uh then you need to know you don't need to place interesting things in that world in in in the world they will look for it themselves uh so you you really have hijacked agents in some particular kind of kind of way and of course for a this this in a is this is situated in a general picture of human nature where in the and we are behaviorist machines so autonomy and agency are not really in the cards anyway so so there's

not nothing really really ethically wrong with the kind of kind of hooked model James Williams has something more to defend he wants to have a more robust IDE of autonomy and freedom that is that is that is at stake um so the hope is here that in activism really can provide a more realist realistic anthropology uh and I think this the success of the attention Merchant shows that we are situated beings uh formed through our interaction with the environment uh and autonomy is not something that puts a boundary in place between us and the world but it needs to be achieved through interactions with the environment so that that that's where it kind of kind of combine the points from from a and Williams I think um and if um I think we're doing still right qu time right right then good yeah I think I think we're yeah we good of time then then I'll make a little Excursion through Neuroscience hopefully to get back to the to the to the same point so I've been a long-term fan of something that's called the affordance competition hypothesis some of you uh uh might note and I think it's it's a general framework for for Neuroscience it's very much in key with with with important an activist principles principles um and what you get from there um it's it of course it's a bit neurocentric but but but you get there is the idea that this is a quote from Paul cisc so decision making is not a single unified Phenomenon with a single neural substrate so we should stop thinking about decision- making as one one thing but rather a disputed process that emerges differently across the nervous system depending on the information that finally DET determines the choice um and you see a lot of work at the moment um there's a both by C but other people as well there's there's a recent paper by Bernard homel which C is a co-author and says nobody knows what attention is so it seems that from a neuroscientific perspective some of those important kind of constructs that we use in every day decision- making attention uh um are not unified single phenomenon but are things executive control is another one of them but are really things that emerge in a particular kind of uh situation depending on the layout of the action possibilities and um so one um important distinctions that CC makes that is that between action specification and action selection um so you see here the this is a kind of General framework that that he's having and you see that there if it if we talk about action selection there's a lot of projecting to the to the Bas of gang and if we talk about action specification there is there is uh uh more more more more cortical ER arrows that are that are being drawn um and in his recent work CC talks about this as within behavior and between Behavior selection so you might think like oh of all the things that I can do there's there's a selection between different kind of behaviors and then in the the classical example of lifting the cup is uh is that that that's a question of action specification right so you and those process

happen in parallel that's not a kind of sequential model but once you decide uh to to to lift a cup the specification is something that that's uh um that's left that that's a different kind of process and typically we have more executive control over the kind of selection process and less over the specification there's no not much use in controlling actively where to where to uh uh uh how to grasp the cup I just want to grasp the the cup um and um so the examples he's giving is is um are related to um the difference between pointing and grasping for example the these are these are makak studies uh so choosing between pointing and grasping is a is a is an action selection uh specifying where to point is action specification um and so neural this to be very different mechanisms for these these these different kind of uh uh forms of selection I mean you might you not you might not even call the second one decision making and so at least from an intuitively from this perspective right the fact that we engage with nowadays with with much of our environment in a kind of pointing kind of way makes it that we make very relevant uh uh behavioral decisions uh am I going to go on Facebook I'm going to write the paper with a swipe of a finger or or or or the point so we use the kind of from that kind of perspective we use the kind of action specification mechanisms for actually things that that intuitively we would like to be forms of action selection and and uh things to be deliberate um so I think there's a also big possibility to to combine this more more neuroscientific angle with the kind of issues on the attention economy and I think the kind of work on affordance competition is very very much in key with with uh uh with with an activism and The crucial bit here is that that from this perspective affordances right we don't have just like a whole row of affordances or so right but this kind of hierarchical organization within them uh some of them are specification some of them are are selection and nested within each other uh and they each of them have different forms of cognitive control associated with them and uh right so let me see uh um so here we have a different kind of mismatch I guess between the Technologies and environment uh and and and and the anthropology that we that we are that we have um this this a mismatch between the structure of Digit digital environments and the structured Behavior or what you might call the affordance uh uh competition and of course this is not something this kind of affordance competition hierarchy is not something that's fixed it might be very much kind dependent on development uh as well but I think it also gives a set of tools to rethink uh about our our relationship with digital uh uh Technologies and in in much of the more uh uh also the more postphenomenological literature on on philosophy of of of of technology and attention um there's really not much interesting interesting uh interest in in cognitive science uh and I think an activism really has a is in a good position here to also take

these insights from cognitive science to the table and still have a robust story about what we want to achieve autonomy an agency so to wrap up so I think an activism is really in a strong position to to to formulate this realistic anthropology for the attention economy and uh this is another talk that says it has been done I have a paper on this but this is really this is where my thinking how how I came from from from thinking about a fores in this more towards this more attention economy topics uh and I think both neuroscientifically in terms of the central concept of an activism there's a really in a good position to to pursue this kind of project so this is where I am at the moment and I would look forward to discuss it with you thank you that's great thank you um thank you very much y there you go um so we um we have at least one of the voice here in the live session with us and I think we may yet be joined by one or two um other latecomers but I guess we'll see if they show um so I obviously as ever have uh many comments and questions but I will also offer the first response to the non-mar member of the the discussion um um I don't there is anything you want to say yeah uh thanks very much J um it's it's interesting to see how considerations from the strong physicalist realist stance of ecological psychology the still emerging and not yet defined feel of an activism and um soot tech technical considerations are coming together I believe that there's an awful lot of um unsteadiness in the conceptual formulations that we're using here which is one of the reasons that we have these seminars of course but I want to draw I want to come to your use of the term anthropology I object um anthropology of course as a discipline has a shameful history of the vois habits of you privileged European males going to people who are culturally distant and um interpreting them from within their own Christian eurocentric cultural point of view now anthropology as a discipline has been through an awful awful lot and it tries to resist strongly positivist formulations to to the extent that it is that it aspires to to generalize to something called the anthropos which is a something in construction but not necessarily finished um the use of the term anthropology must be done then in a in a in a cautious manner when it engages with scientific discourse now you introduced a stoning cultural construct a European cultural construct the psychological subject driven by attention with executive control and decision-making and you can put perception in there as well and there you've got something that we have built here in the West on a largely platonist and Christian Foundation um have constructed methodologically so when it comes to attention for example nobody ever really anymore asks what is attention or does attention exist they ask how do we operationalize attention and you have to ask the same thing about executive control and decision- making not do they exist but how do we operationalize them because if you get too

positivist and realist about those things they go away so I'm worried about your realistic anthropology I think what you're doing by engaging with the psychological subject in this way I don't think you can use anthropology I want to sort of say that's the that's not appropriate I'm coming from a position of EXTREM skepticism with respect to Scientific psychology so so please excuse that I don't expect everyone to share that but I do think the the nature of scientific Uh current scientific practices and the aspirations of a field called anthropology they there's a great tension there and so so that's what I want to draw your attention to good yeah um so I should confess so I'm I'm I'm I I wasn't completely aware of of these tensions when when when when I was using this this uh uh the concept of anthropology um I think and here I'm also a bit I mean all of those concepts are are are troubled right I mean so what what what is implicit in this literature you might think is a picture of human nature but human nature is is just as troubled as as as as I think for me at least I mean I went for anthropology as a kind of lighter notion than than than than human nature but it's it's it's a picture of how people make sense of the world how they arrive at decisions how they attend what kind of control they have over their environment uh and and that picture you can you can distill from from from uh skinner's Beyond freedom and dignity and then you have a picture in which we're enslaved saved by by by by by our environments and and uh the picture you can get from it it's implicit in in in in all the works on the attention economy there is they they even if they're pointing outside if even if they're pointing to to to to all the all the even like Zubov writes about surveillance capitalism it's not about human psychology but it it's it's about the capitalistic system but it all operates with a particular kind of either the liberating agent or or behavioristic agent or something like that so I I I want to zoom in on on on those kind of implicit commitments that are that that that are made and I think there an activism similarly has has as as a position of what it is to be a sense making agent um that comes along with its own kind of vulnerabilities and and and getting those vulnerabilities into view requires you to somehow make make make commitments about it is yeah but but when you say the person I think you're thinking of people like you I don't think you're thinking of this person this is person from the Del fuo one of the crowd who was genocided at the start of the um 20th century um he met anthropologists they didn't understand him people of that tribe even met Charles Darwin Charles Darwin regarded them as animals which is funny because Charles Darwin went on to tell us all that we're animals which is which is a odd but you can see from his reaction he didn't understand them and they had no common basis would you say that any account of decision making

executive control and attention would apply to this person as well as to someone who was brought up within a capitalist um Western heavily industrialized society and if not then it's not anthropology really it's building something within the I'm going to say it neoliberal c um secular capitalist order um so um I I mean the story I present about the role of Technology on on uh um on everyday life is yes it's it's the role of Technology on everyday Western life right I mean that that that's that that's clear and um for people like you and me yeah yeah yeah yeah uh uh and and and and um that's a story I can tell because that's a story I have uh most experienc uh with I I haven't done research in in in in those kind of areas so I'm I me very unfair here I'm I'm sorry so so my the anthropology I describe has much larger aspirations and won't be squashed into any particular Western Viewpoint obviously yeah um but there's a similar tension isn't there between the strongly realist commitments of affordance layouts as described in a gibsonian framework and um the less secure commitments to person body agents individual that Ares within an activism so there maybe as as I said the field is is not yet established so but I yeah isn't it the persistent tension between ecological and anactive approaches which some people don't see as a tension I absolutely do um but it extends all the way out then but I think as well sorry yellow there I mean I as I see it there is a I mean when when y introduced the term he introduced it in the plural right there are multiple anthropologies no that's right yeah and and as such there is sort of an inherent recognition of the boundedness of any of these and the limitations of any of these rather than than sort of placing one as as sort of Superior or more encompassing than the other but rather the anthropology is inherent in it's the the implicit foundation in which um any given description of a specific behavior or or cognitive system or cognitive function is is um presented maybe just to briefly follow up I think the these are anthropologies in in position in literature right so their implicit impositions in the literature rather than their in persons right so so um so when I meant realistic I didn't mean so this is it's it's realistic in the sense that that it's more uh closer to to real life but but not realistic in the sense like this is this is what happens in person this is in no it's it's in that sense it's it's it's a more kind of looking at these positions in the literature and deriving from them the kind of implicit commitments they make to a particular kind of picture of of of of of human nature uh and that's inde that that that's a pluralistic concept without any commitments from my side at least about how that applies to uh uh even those in the west and let let alone to to any and to kind of any human or so so something that kind of generalistic claims I don't I don't think I want to go there or need to go there that's great so I I see Eric has joined I know Eric has a question as well so I'll I'll pass on to you there hey hey

can you hear me yeah yes yeah hi y thanks was very interesting I knew already part of the story of course and it's good to hear you telling it here um I have a question you started out talking about uh technological mediation postphenomenology uh but then you end up with your positive story which is the field of a for es uh in which the field of affordances plays an important role so I was wondering what in the end does this talk about postphenomenology and technological mediation do for you as work doesn't do any work or is it just an idle wheel in in the in the paper that you that you just gave uh and um uh and if not then how will you avoid creating a dichotomy between technological affordances and all the affordances of this aspect of the environment which is my hand and that can also do many things just like an iPhone can yeah yeah know I think I think avoiding this dichotomy is really really important right uh and so you might think about the affordance of VR or so right and that's like no that then the whole environment becomes uh digital in a sense and you you you you you you duplicate the story but what we what we encounter here is I think kind of hybridity where at once I'm sitting reading a book and next to me is a phone which is a simple object visually not much more complicated than the book uh but that allows me to to ENT completely uh uh new domain uh which at least intuitively seems to be a completely new new domain in the sense that one the layout of action possibilities there is is different uh to the kind of things that I can do is so is so much more than than uh I can do here and now uh in in in a non digital environment um so yeah avoiding that doomy is U um is important and therefore it it all needs to kind of be tied back to to somehow like I think one field of affordances that that somehow in in whether you pick up your phone or not kind of Mor so changes changes changes shape and that that that's a question about how to how to how to think about it um and I guess this is this is probably where where where where where postphenomenology can offer some some insights exactly how um this field of affordances as a kind of construct I think it's needed to keep the kind of unity and to avoid the kind of dualism that that you that you were SK sketching but then still how do the Technologies in the environment which are not themselves the affordances but but that that that that that allows you to see through something into new affordances how does that kind of mediational process of intentionality work and I think there are some Concepts from from postphenomenology could could help and I haven't in in in the kind of more in either the inactive or the eological psychology literature found found any kind of good starting points except for I think what what what is the common ground for both an activism and uh and postphenomenology namely the kind of hopon kind of descriptions of of hammers and Canes but that's that's that's that's a two basic kind of example to to to uh to

pursue further okay thanks for now to be continued this stop um okay so I'm I'm just keeping a half eye on the the chat on YouTube and but I do want to throw out a question of my own which is going to be not terribly well formed um but it's a question about something that felt not terribly well formed so I'm hoping that there some kind of resonance there and that was the concept of the agent that's in play here because the you essentially that to an extent was your notion of these multiple anthropologies as well what kind of agent are we talking about and it feels to me that the um there are I guess it wasn't clear what make what moves me from um one being one kind of agent to another under different circumstances because there are certainly times when you know someone might ask me what did you watch on the television yesterday and I said well I watched about 45 minutes of the Netflix menu um and you know that was it and then there are other dimes in which I barely see the Netflix menu because I'm flicking straight through to what it is I'm going to and the the Netflix menu is obviously designed to encourage some sort you know some aspects of that um and and less others but um but my level of commitment now obviously that you know just how vast the Sea of potential options is you know plays a role it makes it very difficult to distinguish well what are the difference between them what do I care about um and and that is there's a an important external not wanting to to get into boundary questions but there's there's an important environmental I guess discussion about uh where my desires are and how I recognize what I want but I I guess I didn't even really see much of a hint towards the well how where do those desires come from or how are they playing a role in in structuring that field of affordances yeah I'm just wondering what what literature do you want to point to and say well we'll use them for the moment and then we'll figure out the details as we go yeah uh no great yeah um so I think the two things here are uh so if you read the more ecological psychology literature on attention uh there uh um attention is always understood attention and distraction are understood relative to a task and I mean in Psychology that that that kind of makes sense right you give people a task but in everyday life that that that that's complicated and I guess the task is already an advance over having a goal right because a goal is some something in your head and then how does it shape your openness to affordances not not not quite clear but I think something like a behavior setting also could be something in the right direction where sometimes we have the right kind of configuration of their environment where it is clear what the purpose of the situation is I'm tired I deserve to uh to to to watch the new new new episode of the crown I know this is the right kind of series and then I've watched it before so so uh this is what I'm going to do and that that's a kind of uh yeah engagement with

technology which which is then I think not detrimental in in in any sense and and just leads you to where you want to go and and and and and that's fine and so I guess the kind of uh uh the kind of really deep distraction kind of moments are the facts the moments where there's not really a task or where task shifting is easier than engaging with the task so sometimes I mean at least personally for me it's like when when writing a paper that's a bit stuck every every progress should try to make that paper uh uh one sentence later the the task has somehow switched to to to add it to social media to checking your mail or whatever right so it's it's it's it's very it's easier to switch tasks than to uh make progress on on on on one particular and of course yeah and then the notion of task has its own complexities and the notion of behavior settings as well but I guess those would be two kind of St stabilizers of everyday actions that are that that that could be made appropriate for for such a kind of way of thinking I think without bringing too much trouble okay thanks yeah it I mean I guess it gets at the how do affordances compete um the the notion of the affordance competition actually captures um some some nice aspects of the Dynamics I think but there's a it becomes that as well well what is the what are the mechanics I guess of that competition how how are they actually getting it you know yeah and and and then uh uh I mean the wrong way to pursue that would be like okay do do do affords compete in the head in my nervous system or do they compete in the world right I mean no that's got to be a more relational story where there's only one competition process that is that is surely uh aided by by the kind of neurodynamics that's going on competitive Dynamics but also by the layout of the world and and and and and and the setting and and and and the practice and part of somehow combining those in in in uh without completely losing the cognitive science I think that that that would be a miss and that's what you find in some of the more post postphenomenology uh literature and also not going completely in Nur istic where in the end everything happens in the brain I think that's that's the from from from this perspective the the challenge um Fred is waving in his camera here so I presume that's a it's yeah it's it's it's a um marrying ecological concepts and an active Concepts is always something of a challenge sense making is an interesting term that sort of does service in both worlds sometimes except that in the ecological framework it's always a sense making of an agent and in action introduced the very interesting formal device of participatory sense making which destroys the notion of a rified individualist experience so one could expect two people sense making together to have an entire if we're going to use affordance language to have a different typology of affordances um which shifts from a resolutely individualist and indeed neurocentric view uh to to a much less wellp specified place I think it's a very

interesting formal intervention from sense making to participatory sense making and I wonder if that has any ramification if that side of the formal thought figures of thought of an action feature in your analysis um good no no so that they have not uh uh yet and um it's it's it's funny and interesting because I think there there's a lot of opportunities there to think about the role of social media and the internet in this in in this context right so there's there's uh um there's people working at at at Google who do like qualitative studies about about people's experience of of social media and they write about the kind of kind of continued sense of social obligation because in my terms the the affordance of replying to a message is always there 24 hours a day because this this this device is there uh and so it it gives that gives a kind of uh uh the kind of messaging that that that's there is there's two individuals that reciprocally send messages to each other so that that that kind of the the shape of that kind of Technology seems to reinforce a kind of uh individualistic me against other people me against the world uh kind of kind of picture rather than I guess kind of more participatory sense making where that whole distinction kind of kind of kind of kind of falls away so I think there that yeah I I haven't really gone there and but I think there's great great kind of both challenges and and and opportunities there for such a kind of framework yeah there's a really interesting question about the temporal Dynamics involved actually because I know there's you know there be occasions where you um you come across a conversation on Twitter but it's a conversation that's a day old or two days old and it's like you don't want to be the the you know someone raising the the undead thread um but then on the converse of that something vaguely approaching participatory sense making is involved in the pylon um where it's like this is happening now go you know everyone just yeah you either have the the horrendous trolleys pylon or you have something that that sort of builds up to you know where you have um a recent one in Ireland was the there was a there's a very um there's a television broadcast that happens once a year called The Toy Show which is a pre-Christmas commercial thing that just this massive event the entire country watches kids stay up late um and they launched a a funding appeal and of course it became this thing that everyone gets involved and piles on the funding appeal so in the course of about three and a half hours they raised six million euro um but because of precisely the the the kinds of dynamics that that kind of um Twitter and the internet allowed um and so that there is a there's a Fascination uh some really interesting questions about the kinds of Dynamics I think particularly the temporal dynamics that different Technologies allow um that uh that there is the possibility for participatory sense making through these these forms of mediation as well and uh uh I think yeah that's a great example I

think another one is also the fact that I mean on Twitter you you interact by by text that are written down right so uh every statement there is by definition the preposition uh and and so in a conversation I can start with an opposition and and and we find convergence but the very fact that that it's already written down right you you cannot backtrack so easily on the things that you said uh when when things are written down than than when when things are uh when you're in the conversation where where indeed and kind of participatory way you can you can find common ground or something like this so again I think one of the reasons why discussions escalate so quickly is that no this is you need to stand your ground because you you you you put down your cards right and and Well normally in the conversation we we we don't do that without shame you can you can you can oh no yeah it's maybe yeah maybe I phrase it in the wrong kind of way let me rephrase it and that that kind of turn taking participatory interactive process is something that's just that's just not not facilitated by that kind of technological structure natural language isn't literal no no no no it's literal you know written Languages by Def by definition so it's a yeah it's a really good point um so that is a we're sort of getting on towards our our our finish time so I'll um I I guess I'll give a warning for anyone who wants to throw a a text up on the the the YouTube chat just if you want to jump in at a a last minute intervention um and Fred or Eric if either you'd like to make a final comment but um with with that I think we might um bring the the session to a close so y thank you very much for that presentation and there's yeah lots of nice food for thought that was a rich ground for digging [Music] in well there's certainly plenty for a three-year post talk that is for sure so thank you thanks very much for giving you time for the enel seminars and yeah we look forward hopefully we can meet again in person soon as well it be fantastic yeah great very good okay thanks everyone and we will see you next month for Manuel Aris esano for who will kick off January 2021 if we ever get there cool